

INDIAN INSTITUTES OF MANAGEMENT BRAND RECALL

Dusty Ahmedabad, 1971. I got in by train and took an auto-rickshaw. The Indian Institute of Management-Ahmedabad (IIM-A) was not well-known. "After Atira" was how it was described; I paid one and a half times the fare, crossed the waterless Sabarmati, turned up at a campus still being built.

I was lucky. Many first-year students had to stay in faculty houses. I got into a dorm: D-1. Today, it is an all-women dorm. On my visits, I usually knock on Room 18 and say "hello" to the resident young lady and tell her that I lived in her room many years ago. I get an incredulous look.

The thing about IIM-A that hit you right between the eyes was how different it was from the traditional Indian university. There was no ragging. Seniors came up to you and offered help. The study pressure was gruelling. You had to be prepared every day. And if you could not sound intelligent through class participation or CP, as we called it, you were in trouble. Over time, we all figured out how to beat the CP requirements; various techniques

became the specialties of different individuals. "I agree/disagree with him," was a useful opening line. Or better still "I find the data in exhibit 4 of page 35 of the case puzzling". Data can always be puzzling and, I have proved that I have read up to page 35 and actually looked at the exhibits.

We were very lucky simply because of the galaxy of professors. S. K. Bhattacharyya in accounting, Kuchhal Sahib in finance, Kamla Chowdhury and Ishwar Dayal in organisational behaviour, C. Rangarajan (he later became governor of the RBI) and Charan Wadhwa in economics. But above all, there was the graceful and all-pervading presence of Ravi Mathai, teacher par-excellence and intrepid, accessible leader with a difference. There were younger professors who dazzled you in different ways. J. G. Krishnappa with his sophisticated jokes that went above us, Sasi Misra with his elegant cynicism, Keshav Prasad with his ebullience, Suresh Seshan who remembered everyone's first names, Amar Kalro with his understated brilliance. The teachers treated us not

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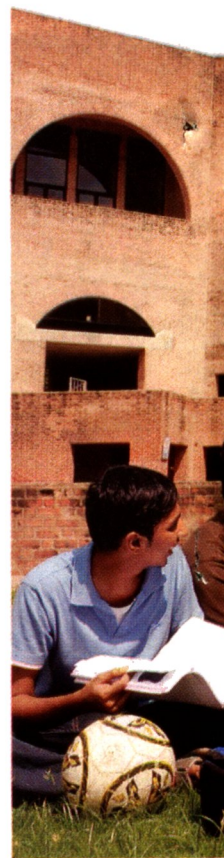
The number of students who compete for fewer than 1,200 general seats in the IIMs, the first of which was set up in 1961.

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The number of new IIMs coming up in Jammu and Kashmir, Tamil Nadu, Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, Uttarakhand and Haryana.

THE TOUGHEST

In 2001, *The Economist* termed IIM-Ahmedabad to be the toughest B-School to get admission in the world.



ON A MISSION: Kang in his office



RAVI S SAHANI

"The PAU is changing its research to push up the food security of the country."

MANJIT SINGH KANG, VICE-CHANCELLOR, PUNJAB AGRICULTURAL UNIVERSITY

PUNJAB AGRICULTURAL UNIVERSITY, LUDHIANA GRAIN GLORY

It was the mid-1960s. Having fought two back-to-back wars against China and Pakistan, India found itself pitched against another debilitating problem—a food crisis, worsened by severe drought. It was then that a comprehensive plan for raising agricultural production was drawn and it led to the birth of the Punjab Agricultural University (PAU) at Ludhiana in 1963, one of India's first two farm universities. Since its inception, the PAU has developed 558 high-yielding varieties of food grains, vegetables and fruits and was instrumental in heralding the green revolution in the north. Despite facing a funds crunch, it is working closely with farmers by regularly organising 'kisan melas' where new farming technologies are transferred to them. "We need a fresh fusion of funds to regain the old glory and seed the second green revolution," says Vice-Chancellor Manjit Singh Kang.

by Ramesh Vinayak